Journal of Humanities and Social Sciences Invention
Vol. 0, No. 0, 2023, 1-7
ISSN: 2581-8791

Impact of Ancient Nature Sensibility on Contemporary Indian Environmental Policies

Kanika Raj, Ripu Sudan Singh

Department of Political Science, Babasaheb Bhimrao Ambedkar, Central University, Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh, India

Publication Info

Article History:
Received: 00-00-2022
Accepted: 00-00-2022
DOI: 10.35210/jhssi.1.1.1

Keywords:
Ancient environmental culture, Indian Environment Policy, Nature sensibility, Tradition.

Corresponding Author:
author
M: +00 000000000
Email: mailid

Abstract

Modern times have seen an increase in environmental concerns. There are ongoing national and international efforts to find a solution to this issue. India is an important player in the environmental endeavor. It is one of the ancient civilizations with remarkable environmental history too. Indian culture and customs exhibit a strong nature sensibility. This article seeks to analyze the influence of ancient consciousness on contemporary policies. It examines the Indian culture as the ideational factor behind the environmental strategy. The old conscience has inspired modern policymakers to review and use ancient knowledge in contemporary environmental actions. The old wisdom has served as a perpetual source of inspiration for modern innovations.

INTRODUCTION

In Sanskrit, the equivalent word for the environment is 'Paryāvarana'. This word is constituted as- pari + ā + vṛ-anat in which the earlier prefix means 'fully', the second means' completely' and the root have the sense of 'covering'. Thus, it refers to the environment which entirely surrounds the living creatures, especially the human being, whose existence depends upon it. Consequently, the organism's survival depends greatly on the environment's equilibrium. However, the unrestricted way of life has disrupted the environment's equilibrium. At present, Growing industrialization, urbanization, indiscriminate exploitation of natural resources and other anthropogenic factors has led to the degradation of the environment. This has resulted in several environmental issues, like pollution, global warming, climate change, loss of biodiversity, etc., which ultimately threaten human life. A solution must be found for this. At both the global and local levels, efforts are being made in unison to address this growing issue.

India is an important factor in this endeavor. With the second-largest population in the world, it plays a significant role in preserving and protecting the environment. At the same time, India has also been one of the ancient civilizations and has a remarkable environmental history. The ancient culture of India included several environmentally friendly practices and traditions. India had formulated guidelines to define and nurture the man-nature relationship in its traditions. The ancient environmental practices of India have served as a model for the modern world. It has demonstrated how ancient people lived in harmony with nature, how nature sensibility was ingrained in their way of life, and how they practiced sustainable living.

The cultural identity can be regarded as the ideational factor that has contributed to shaping India's environmental policy. This article proceeds to understand the ancient traditions and then to examine its influence on contemporary policies and actions.

India's Ancient Environmental Traditions

India's topography and climate have been favorable for both man and nature since ancient times. The Indian subcontinent was home to a wide variety of plants and animals, as well as rivers, mountains, forests, etc. Numerous perennial rivers nourished by snowmelt and rainwater have been bestowed by nature on the Indian landmass. A human connection had been on Indian soil since the dawn of time. The expansive Indus River plain was the site of the first settlements in India. People in the Indus Valley venerated a variety of creatures, including humped bulls, elephants, and trees like pipal. In Indian culture and social life, it is still widely used. The Harappans were also knowledgeable about a variety of techniques for managing and preserving water for irrigation.

The Vedic culture then developed across the subcontinent. The Vedic people, who largely worshipped nature, had significant concerns about ecology and its management. The goal of the hymns of the Rig Veda is to appease the gods, who are each represented by a strong natural force, such as the sun (Surya), wind (Vayu), morning (Ushas), the bull (Parjanya), and fire (Agni). The Rig-Veda establishes the symbolism of man-environment close kinship when it says: 'Heaven is my father; my mother is this vast earth, my close kin.'" It is said "Do Not Harm the Environment; Do Not Harm the water and the Flora; Earth Is My Mother, I Am Her Son '(Mata Bhumih Putroham Prithivyah)'.

The Vedas emphasize the need for Forest Development and Protection. The Vedas place a strong emphasis on the fact that plants and trees are heirloom treasures. Aranyani (the forest) is referred to both the Atharva Veda and the Rig Veda

as a deity that provides food without cultivation. All of the Vedic educational institutions (gurukulas) were situated in forest locations, where the quiet atmosphere fosters the development of excellent thoughts and devout concepts. Since the students and gurus lived in a natural setting, it stands to reason that they were concerned with preserving and protecting it.

The ancient Indians had a deep reverence for the natural world and held a variety of natural phenomena in the highest regard. The earliest Indians seem to have lived in harmony with nature and in deference to Rta, the natural rule. The sages of the Upanishads believed that god existed in trees and other plants since they were given to man as a companion for their shared survival. The Iso-Upanishad has unveiled the mysteries of life's origins on earth and the significance of each organism to the survival of all others. It has been regarded that The Lord is the rightful owner of the universe and all its creatures. There is no superior creation than another. No species should infringe on the rights and privileges of another. Ancient India is known for having this level of consciousness of nature.

Epics, like The Ramayana and the Mahabharata, make numerous references to the environment. The Bhisma Parva of the Mahabharata describes the planet as an "ever-yielding cow" as long as its resources are cultivated and maintained balanced and controlled. The tree is compared to the universe in the Mahabharata, with a single trunk and many branches.

Buddhism & Jainism

Buddha's dedication and compassion for nature are evident in his entire life. His birth, enlightenment, first sermon, and nirvana are all significant occasions that are strongly related to natural settings and demonstrate his deep appreciation for the natural world. The Vinaya Pitaka is filled with examples highlighting environmental issues and the necessity of maintaining harmony between living and non-living things. The monks were encouraged to preserve trees. Ashoka promoted his message of forest conservation by taking a number of steps to safeguard forestry and outlaw the indiscriminate killing of birds and other animals for sustenance. The Agganna-sutta offers a wonderful way to combine morality with the environment. Buddhist writings emphasize the need for close co-existence between humans and nature. Even still, a lot of academics consider Buddhism to be a form of religious ecology. Buddhism has always emphasized the importance of living in complete harmony with the environment and seeing all living things as fellow inhabitants of this earth. In Buddhism, nature is regarded as a teacher, a spiritual force, and a way of life. It emphasizes the need to preserve nature while keeping the needs of future generations and other living things in mind.

Jainism's ahimsha principle was followed regarding all living things, including plants, animals, and people. The fact that Vardhamana Mahavira and Lord Buddha both gained kevalagyana (supreme wisdom) under two giant trees—Mahavira under a sal tree and Buddha under an aswastha vriksha known as the Bodhi tree—on the banks of the rivers Rajupalika and Niranjana, respectively—is extremely significant. This shows that how man could be able to attain supreme knowledge in serene and pollution free environment

The puranas also emphasize the necessity of tree plantations while recalling the benefits of plants and trees. In India, "Vanmahotsava" (Tree Plantation Ceremony) has been a tradition for more than 1500 years. Even in the Arthasastra, it was considered that it was the responsibility of the people to protect water sources like rivers and cisterns. Kautilya makes a case for the creation of abhayranya or abhayavana, sanctuaries for both trees and animals, where both could live without worrying about being killed. In addition, Kautilya outlined the duties of a forest superintendent and the consequences of poaching and other acts that harm forests, particularly productive ones.

Animals were valued, cared for, and even worshipped by the ancient Indians because they understood that they had a right to coexist with humans. The animals were given the status of gods and goddesses to impress upon the commoners their importance. They believed that the Almighty takes on several animal guises. Horses and cattle are described in-depth in the Upanishads. Fish and turtle life histories can be found in the Garudapurana. Additionally, there are religious writings that are devoted to a certain animal. These teachings, which predate most other world texts, include extremely contemporary ideas like the genesis of life, organic evolution, and environmental science. In Indian mythology, lions are affiliated with Goddess Durga, cows are associated with Krishna, snakes are revered, the Sun God rides seven horses, Vanar Sena aids Lord Ram, and Hanuman is related with monkeys and apes.

Ancient Indians divinized nature and established well-formulated norms to define and foster a relationship between man and nature free of exploiting tendencies. They used to worship the manifestations of nature and led a sustainable way of life. This Indian consciousness has been the part of Indian culture and history. In contemporary times, too, it has become a determinant of India's environmental policy.

Impact on Contemporary Environmental Policies

The nation's culture and history are considered by policymakers while drafting any policy. Contemporary environmental laws and programmes reflect the values of traditional environmental sensibility. Indian policymakers often claim that sustainable development, conservation, and resource management have been part and parcel of the Indian culture, especially in the pre-colonial era. This has been evidenced by the government's overt and covert actions. Recently, the Indian government has cited verses from the Vedas and Upanishads in speeches, catalogs, and policy papers. It demonstrates the impact of culture. The government is fusing contemporary environmental initiatives with existing environmental values. This could be viewed as the ideational factor that influenced the action of the policymakers.

In the official document of "Nationally Determined Contribution" for the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change Conference of the Parties, 2015, India's document epigram cited the Veda: "Unto Heaven be Peace, Unto the Sky and the Earth be Peace, Peace be unto the Water, Unto the Herbs and Trees be Peace." The text then asserts, "India has a long history and tradition of harmonious co-existence between man and nature. Human beings here have regarded fauna and flora as part of their family." The reiteration of Sanskrit shlokas conveying nature sensibility has been frequent.

At UNESCO, Paris in 2015, Prime Minister of India, Narendra Modi, asserted the need to revive, preserve and nurture traditional knowledge. He emphasized that culture holds the secrets to economic, efficient, and, environment-friendly solutions for many of the problems.

In 2015, The "PARAMPARA" Catalogue was released by the Indian government, which provides a glimpse of the traditions that more obviously connect with climate change and sustainable living. The traditional practices highlighted in the document have been organized under eight themes or sectors:

Solar and Wind Energy

India has abundant sunshine and a breeze from nature. Indian society, lifestyle, and culture have long valued and regarded

these natural elements as essential. The Adityahridayam Strota, which traditional performers frequently utilize, recognizes the sun as a significant energy source for heat and light as well as the creator of seasons. The sun's energy is also used extensively in daily life for food production, processing, drying, clothing, shelter, etc. According to Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has the potential to become a "country of solar power" by utilizing cutting-edge technologies to produce pure solar energy. India and France established the International Solar Alliance to mobilize efforts against climate change by deploying solar energy solutions. It was conceptualized on the sidelines of the 21st Conference of Parties (COP21) to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) held in Paris in 2015. Through the consolidation of demand for solar finance, technologies, innovation, research and development, and capacity building, its goal is to scale up solar energy and lower the cost of solar power production.

Agriculture

India's economy has historically been predominately agricultural. Traditional adaptation and mitigation techniques have been extremely important in reducing greenhouse gas emissions and promoting sustainability. National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture (NMSA) has been operational from 2014-15. Which aims at making agriculture more productive, sustainable, remunerative and climate resilient by promoting location specific integrated /composite farming systems; soil and moisture conservation measures; comprehensive soil health management; efficient water management practices and mainstreaming rainfed technologies. The Indian government is implementing the Paramparagath Krishi Vikas Yojana to encourage organic farming methods.

Biodiversity

Traditionally India communities deeply respected the biodiversity around them both flora and fauna. The Atharvaveda, one of the earliest collections of Indian scripture, has something to say about the earth: "Whatever we take from you, O Earth, May that fast regenerate again; may we not injure thy essential habitat and heart". One of the key forces behind climate mitigation and adaptation is biodiversity. In India, traditional wisdom is a crucial instrument for resolving the problems caused by climate change.

Food

Indians have traditionally valued food. India has a predominantly plant-based diet. By itself, this reduces carbon footprint. The Indian way of life emphasizes eating food that is in season, and ancient Indian medical systems support this idea. Lowering the energy requirements associated in processing, packaging, storing, and transporting non-local, non-seasonal food lowers the ecological footprint. The International Year of Millets 2023 is one such instance. India sought to introduce the globe to its ancient, environmentally friendly coarse cereals.

Health

Vedic history serves as the origin of India's ancient healthcare system. The traditional health rejuvenation systems have developed out of a profound awareness of how bio-resources and human physiology interact, including the effects of climate, seasons, weather, and lifestyles on the mind-body connection. Intensification of natural disasters, wider spread of vector-borne illnesses like dengue and malaria, and more frequent heat and cold waves are all effects of climate change that significantly negatively impact human health and raise health-related stress. In this situation, India's traditional healthcare systems will prove to be a major asset in providing the big population with affordable yet effective treatment alternatives. A national strategy on Indian Systems of Medicine has been released by the Ministry of AYUSH, Government of India, in an effort to improve healthcare services and address the problems of the health risks brought on by climate change. Yoga and Ayurveda are two of India's offerings to the globe.

Shelter

The use of locally available eco-friendly building materials, the adoption of energy-efficient processes, and design that is appropriate to the local weather and climatic conditions are just a few of the features and procedures that make up the traditional practices of shelter building in Indian society. Building on conventional wisdom, the Indian government has introduced a number of ambitious initiatives, such as the Smart Cities Mission, to create a new generation of energy-efficient cities that provide low-carbon public services and promote sustainable living. Urban planning, economic development, and historical preservation are all intertwined under the National Heritage City Development and Augmentation Yojana (HRIDAY).

Textile, Clothing and Lifestyle Products

The best way to explain Indian textiles, apparel, and lifestyles is to combine improvisation, philosophy, artisanal skills, and a shared dedication to making do with little. India's textile, clothing, and lifestyle system, which includes handmade textiles and garment recycling, may pave the way for lowering greenhouse gas emissions.

Water

India has a long history of managing and collecting water. Communities respect water and know how crucial it is to conserve it, especially when it comes to rainwater, to meet their long-term water needs. One similar endeavor is the Catch the Rain programme.

Through in-depth information about India's culture of climate-friendly sustainable practices, the government made an attempt to increase knowledge about climate change, adaptation and mitigation in relation to culture and tradition.

In 2018, at the inauguration of the World Sustainable Development Summit, Prime Minister emphasized the importance of our ancient traditional practices that could contribute to a sustainable lifestyle. He said that their goal is to be able to live up to the ancient texts which say, 'Keep pure For the Earth is our Mother and we are her children'. The PM asserted that this was the ideal they sought to live through their actions. He said that all resources and all wealth belong to Nature and the Almighty and we are just the trustees or managers of this wealth. Mahatma Gandhi, too, advocated this trusteeship philosophy. Through these remarks, the Indian Prime Minister laid the significance of ancient traditions on contemporary actions. Similarly, the Prime Minister emphasized the sun's importance in Indian philosophy during the opening session of the International Solar Alliance's Founding Conference in New Delhi in 2018. The sun was regarded as the world's soul thousands of years ago in the Vedas. He emphasized that when looking for solutions to the problem of climate change, we would need to consider the comprehensive approach and balance of ancient philosophy.

For the pioneering work in championing the International Solar Alliance and promoting new areas of levels of cooperation on environmental action, Narendra Modi, Prime Minister of

India, along with Emmanuel Macron, President of France were awarded the Champions of the Earth, the UN's highest environmental honor in 2018. PM in his address at UNEP' Champions of the Earth' award, remarked that the champions of the Earth Award is an honor to that ancient tradition of India that sees the god in nature, that invokes the god in the five basic elements of the creation - earth, sky, fire, water and air. It was an honor to that Indian lady for whom reuse and recycle has been part of daily life for centuries, who sees the form of god in the plants, who pluck the leaves of Tulsi plant by counting them and for whom feeding food-grain to ants is an act of righteous deed. He talked of Indian philosophy regarding the environment and nature and emphasized the need to make climate concerns part of the so-called modern culture.

In the event, PM said, there "In our tradition we say, O Goddess Earth, the wife of Lord Vishnu, who dons the seas as her clothes and whose body is in the form of mountains, I bow down to you. Please forgive me because I place my feet on you. This sensitivity is part of our life. Worshipping the plants and trees, celebrating the weather and seasons for fasting and as festivals, and talking about the relationship with nature in our folklore, we have always considered nature a living being. In our tradition, the well-being of the entire universe is considered the most important thing because of this relationship with nature. In this Sanskrit Shlok (verse) it is prayed to God: May there be peace in air; may there be peace in space; may there be peace on the earth; may there be peace in water; may there be peace in herbs and medicines; may there be peace in the trees and plants; may there be peace in the world; may there be peace in all the gods. In our tradition, no yajna or ritual is being considered complete without invoking this mantra for the peace in the entire world, it is not considered complete till the time it is invoked." Because of this, he claimed, "The award you gave me is an honor to the people of India and an honor to the principles people hold."

The Prime Minister and the Indian administration have frequently emphasized the influence of old customs on governmental policies. The spirit of Indian culture and traditions is a newly reinvigorated discourse in the environmental policy that has shaped the action too. Recently, in November 2021, on the occasion of the COP 26 Summit, Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi presented the idea of Mission Life. It is envisioned as an India-led global mass movement that will nudge individual and collective action to protect and preserve the environment.

Mission LIFE

Lifestyle for Environment. It focuses on the Environmental Conscious Life Style. Today, mindful and deliberate utilization is needed instead of Mindless and Destructive Consumption. These movements together can set goals that can revolutionize many sectors such and diverse areas such as fishing, agriculture, wellness, dietary choices, packaging, housing, hospatility, tourism, clothing, fashion, water management and energy.

At the launch of Mission LiFE at the Statue of Unity, Gujarat, PM remarked that we can build a better future only by learning from the past. India had a rich tradition of worshipping nature for thousands of years. The importance of water, land, air and all natural things has been accurately explained in the Vedas. He said that Mission LiFE will encompass every lifestyle related to the conservation of nature, which our ancestors adopted, and that can be made a part of our lifestyle today. The Prime Minister underlined that Mission LiFE makes the fight against climate change democratic, in which everyone can contribute with their respective capacities. The Prime Minister elaborated that Mission LiFE emboldens the spirit of the P3 model, i.e. Pro Planet People. It functions on the basic principles of ‹Lifestyle of the planet, for the planet and by the planet›.

He also threw light on the concept of ‹Reduce, Reuse and Recycle' and circular economy and mentioned that it has been a part of the Indian lifestyle for thousands of years. He added that Mission LiFE can be successful only when it reaches every corner of the world. He gave the mantra—Prakriti Rakshati Rakshita—that is, those who protect nature, nature protects them. The mission aims to make a better sustainable world. Mission LiFE is designed with the objective to mobilize at least one billion Indians and other global citizens to take individual and collective action for protecting and preserving the environment in the period 2022 to 2027. Within India, at least 80% of all villages and urban local bodies are aimed to become environment-friendly by 2028.

Indian government has also launched 'One Sun, One World, One Grid' system. During its launch at C0P 26 Summit in Glasgow, Prime Minister gave remarks at the session on 'Accelerating Clean Technology Innovation and Deployment'. He said, "In the Surya Upanishad, thousands of years ago, it was said that everything has originated from the sun, the source of all energy is the sun, and everything is sustained by the energy of the sun. But in the modern era, man in the race to overtake the cycle set by the sun, disturbed the natural balance and caused great damage to his environment. If we are to re-establish a balanced life with nature, our sun will illuminate this path. We have to walk along with the sun again to save the future of humanity. The quantum of energy that the entire human race consumes in a year, the sun gives the same amount of energy to the earth in one hour. And this enormous energy is completely clean, sustainable." This creative initiative will not only reduce the carbon footprint and cost of energy but will also open a new avenue of cooperation between different regions and countries. The idea of One Sun, One World, One Grid can be a remarkable initiative in the transformation from fossil fuels to clean energy. India has supported the initiative with citing the connection with ancient traditions.

CONCLUSION

Indian philosophy and lifestyle have long been rooted in the concept of co-existence with nature. Conservation is ingrained in the Indian ethos, and the inspirations from them can be drawn in modern times. Indian culture has a lot to offer to the world, and the Indian government is making efforts to connect the traditional ancient Indian Environment ideas with contemporary environmental efforts. Constant citations of ancient verses, mantras and practices is an effort to rejuvenate the eco-friendly and sustainable way of life in India and globally. It could help India as her soft power and would enhance her influence in global negotiations and efforts.

Both domestic and foreign environmental policies have been affected by the identity of ancient civilizations. The nature sensibility of the past could well reinvigorate contemporary efforts. Indian Policymakers have aptly combined modern science with ancient wisdom and practices to create an appealing strategy. However, critics have claimed it as a lack of strategic vision and the problems associated with an idealistic world.

It can be said that a lot of expenditure has been incurred towards Research and Development by governments and international organizations in a bid to find solutions for a sustainable future. Countries have failed to realize the abundance of knowledge contained in its own spiritual and cultural heritage. This is particularly true in the case of oriental countries. India, in

this case, has realized the importance of its ancient knowledge. It has a great source of information pertaining to environmental protection in its sacred books like the Vedas, Upanishads and Puranas. These traditional views hold good even in the 21st century for sustainable development. In this way, the ancient traditions has served as moral support and guide to the Indian environmental programs and policies. It has helped to innovate new ideas using new technologies, with the incorporation of ancient wisdom.

REFERENCES

Roy, Ashim and Roy, Alpana (2017). Enviornmental conservation in ancient India. *International Journal of Sanskrit Research*, *3*(4), 139–142 https://www.anantaajournal.com/archives/2017/vol3issue4/PartC/3-4-5-313.pdf

Ganguly, Anirban. (2012). *Man and Environment in India: Past Traditions and Present Challenges*. Vivekanda International Foundation. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://www.vifindia.org/article/2012/july/26/man-and-environment-in-india-past-traditions-and-present-challenges

Thakur, Bipin. (2019). History of Environmental Conservation (Ancient and Medieval Periods). *International Journal of Multidisciplinary Research Review*, *4*(5), 1072–1077. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/334548611_History_of_Environmental_Conservation_Ancient_and_Medieval_Periods

Jayaram, Dhanasree. (2021). *Climate Diplomacy and Emerging Economies: India as a Case Study.* 1st Edition. New York. Routledge

INDIA'S INTENDED NATIONALLY DETERMINED CONTRIBUTION: WORKING TOWARDS CLIMATE JUSTICE. (2015). Government of India. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://ksdma.karnataka.gov.in/storage/pdf-files/India%20INDC.pdf

PARAMPARA: India's Culture of Climate Friendly Sustainable Practices. (2015). In *Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change*. Government of India. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://moef.gov.in/wp-content/themes/moef-green/ebook/parampara-ebook/Parampara_2016_Ebook.html#page/4

International Solar Alliance. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://isolaralliance.org/about/background

National Mission for Sustainable Agriculture. (2018). PIB Delhi. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1556469#:~:text=National%20Mission%20for%20Sustainable%20Agriculture%20(NMSA)%20has%20been%20made%20operational,soil%20and%20moisture%2-0conservation%20measures%3B

Text of PM's address at the inauguration of World Sustainable Development Summit (WSDS 2018). (2018). PIB Delhi. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetail.aspx?PRID=1520731

English rendering of PM's address at UNEP' Champions of the Earth' Award. (2018). PIB Delhi. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetail.aspx?PRID=1548564

PM & UNSG Launch Mission LiFE at Statue of Unity, Gujarat. (2022). PIB Delhi. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1869550

English Translation of Prime Minister's remarks at the session on 'Accelerating Clean Technology Innovation and Deployment' at COP26 Summit in Glasgow. (2021). PIB Delhi. Retrieved February 24, 2023, from https://pib.gov.in/PressReleseDetail.aspx?PRID=1769062

Query Report

Q1 Kindly provide corresponding author name.

Q2 Kindly provide Short title of the article.

Q3 Kindly provide reference in-text citations in APA format.

Q4 Cross-check for accuracy/data/format, correct, and provide all references in consistent APA format. Sample reference formatted to act as an example and to maintain consistency of format (APA) required

Chandra, S., Sikdar, P. K., & Kumar, V. (1995). Dynamic PCU estimation of capacity on urban roads. *Journal of Indian Roads Congress, 23*, 17–28.

Chandra, S. (2004). Capacity estimation procedure for two-lane roads under mixed traffic conditions. *Journal of Indian Roads Congress, 165*(1), 139–170."